

LETTER OF APOLOGY

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Increase awareness of hurtful behavior toward others.
2. Increase sensitivity toward the impact of hurtful behavior on others.
3. Take steps toward making amends through a letter of apology for hurtful behavior toward others.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Anger Management
- Chemical Dependence
- Chemical Dependence—Relapse
- Family Conflict
- Intimate Relationship Conflicts
- Legal Conflicts

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Hurtful behavior toward others is easily minimized or denied in terms of who is responsible for it or the impact it has on others. This assignment increases sensitivity toward the impact that hurtful behavior has had on others. Processing the exercise, it is important that the client include all elements of a constructive apology and avoid projection or minimization. Review each letter of apology to make sure it contains all the necessary elements. Evaluate whether the client demonstrates genuine feelings of regret, shame, or guilt. Clearly confront denial and emphasize the negative impact of insensitive behaviors.

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After we become aware of the pain we have caused someone else due to our own unkind behavior, we must try to find a way to heal the hurt and make amends. Many times just saying “I’m sorry” is not enough. It can be helpful if the apology is accompanied by a written note acknowledging causing the pain and suggesting how you could have done things differently. This assignment asks you to describe three incidents in which you have hurt others. It then asks you to construct a brief letter of apology for each of these incidents.

Three Hurtful Incidents

Describe for each of three incidents who was hurt, what you did to hurt them, how they felt about what you did, how you feel now about what you did, and how you could have acted more kindly.

Incident #1: _____

Incident #2: _____

Incident #3: _____

Apology

Write a letter of apology to each of the people who were hurt in each of the three incidents described. Include in your letter of apology a description of what you did to hurt them, your perception of how your actions must have affected them, how you feel today about your actions, and what you wished you would have done in the place of your hurtful behavior.

Incident #1:

Dear _____:

[illegible]

Sincerely,

Incident #2:

Dear _____:

[illegible]

Sincerely,

Dear _____:

Sincerely,